Medal Detector

Junior teams excel at World Championships

By Amy Casanova

The 19th World Youth Team Championships were held in Salsomaggiore Terme, Italy, in July.

At the closing ceremony, the U.S. finished with three silver medals, one bronze medal and a Joan Gerard Sportsmanship Award.

The United States Bridge Federation reported that this year's Junior bridge accomplishments included the strongest overall performance by all teams: Every team showed they were competitive in their field, with six of 10 teams in the quarterfinal, four of six in the semifinal and three of four making it to the final.

The U.S. teams won the most knockout medals – three silver and one bronze – (previously it was two silver and one bronze) and the first U26 KO medal since 2006 (when current USA1 nonplaying captain Joe Grue won a gold medal).

It was also the most teams the USBF Junior program has ever sent – two teams in each category.

The Canadian Bridge Federation sent two teams. "We had high hopes for our Juniors this year to get to the medal round, but it was not to be," said Andy Stark, who coordinates the Junior program. "The Europeans are really good, and we could have played better. But we learned a lot and will be back in 2027."

The Canadian U26 team, Cindy He, Max Cheng, Olivia Laufer, Martin Zhao, Quan Chen and Connor Havens, had some previous international experience. Their npc was Terry Du. The U16 team was composed of Casper Gu, William Liu, Honwell Xing, Aydan Jia, Nina Ke and Rudy Cheng. Their npc was Terrence Rego, who performed his job both in the six-month lead up to the WYTCs and in Salsomaggiore. Both teams trained by playing a weekly game on BBO and going over results with the npcs and mentors, such as Shan Huang and Danny Miles.

"Our selection process was modeled after the American Trials as I had consulted with the USBF Junior coordinator Amber Lin, who was gracious with her time," said Stark. "To catch up to the experience levels of the European teams, we will have to work harder. Casper Gu has already set up a weekly online game for any and all Canadian juniors!"

Daniel Balof played on the bronze medal-winning U21 team. He is a student at the University of Notre Dame in mathematics, philosophy and constitutional studies. He shared the following:

Many people think to win at bridge one must be smarter, more clever, more ingenious than their opponents. This is a critical misconception. Instead, success at bridge, even at the highest levels, is about avoiding costly mistakes. On the back of one of my own attempts for brilliancy (see 7♥ down one), my team lost the semifinal despite leading the first three sets. So, when we won the first set of the bronze medal match by 28, our captain, Aaron Silverstein, decided to remind us that not losing is just as good as winning.

"Do this," he said, holding out both arms to indicate a basket, "and catch the IMPs they throw at you.

"Don't do this," he continued, flinging his arms above his head, "and throw the IMPs right back."

We cruised in the second and third sets, and England's withdrawal (down by 90 IMPs) let us hit the metaphorical and literal showers early. The only remaining question was why Aaron hadn't told us this before the semifinal match.

Dlr: East
Vul: E–W
Bd. 22

	♠ A Q ♥ K Q 10 3 2 ♦ Q 4 ♣ A K J 7	
♠ K 9 7 5 3 ♥ 8 7 5 ♦ K 10 9 7 ♣ 5	N W E S	♠ J 10 8 6 ♥ 6 ♦ 8 6 5 3 2 ♣ Q 10 9
	♠ 4 2 ♥ A J 9 4 ♦ A J ♣ 8 6 4 3 2	

West	*Silverstein*	*East*	*Balof*
		Pass	Pass
Pass	2♣	Pass	2♦
Pass	2♥	Pass	2♠
Pass	3♥	Pass	4NT
Pass	5♦	Pass	5NT
Pass	6♣	Pass	7♥
All Pass			

At the time, I knew I was lacking some key information. But I thought, in the worst-case scenario, partner is 5–4 without the ♣Q – and even then we have chances. Of course, this means I should probably offer 7♣, but I was too busy trying to figure out what level of hearts to bid. Bridge can be a very psychologically challenging game, and I think the fact that I was trying to get in the heads of the pair at the other table, as well as the fact that I knew the match might come down to this was affecting me. But most of all, I was thinking, "don't do it, don't do it, don't do it" – so I did it.

At the other table, they played 6♥ making six, for a loss of 14 IMPs.

The USA1 squad led in the semifinal against USA2 after every segment, by 14, 19, and 17 IMPs. In the fourth and final segment, USA2 outscored USA1 by 24 IMPs to win the match 125–118.

Jayson Lee of Hillsborough CA played on the Under-16 USA2 squad with his sister, Kate. "The town was overfilled with youth bridge players from around the world," Jayson reported. "We played hundreds of hands against players from India, Thailand, England, Norway, Israel and more. Unfortunately, we didn't qualify for the knockouts, but we did much better during the BAM, placing fifth. Hopefully next time we can even medal!"

Some of the best parts about the WYTCs are the moments away from the intense competition. "All the U.S. team members stayed in the same hotel, and we ate all our meals together," said Jayson. "We would stuff our faces with incredible pizza and pasta while talking about all the crazy boards we played that day – something that would never fail to make me laugh. We played 50 hands during the day, and we would play another 20 just for the fun of it in the evening."

"Italy was an amazing experience," echoed Kate. "I really enjoyed playing cards in the common room after the bridge event with the other U.S. players. We would play games like goulash and five-card bridge, and it was just a great way to connect with everyone and destress after a busy day of bridge."

"All these moments made the WYBTC one of my most memorable experiences," said Jayson. "I think it helped build the U.S. youth bridge community indefinitely, and I will always remember the 2025 Worlds as an amazing event that was full of fun and laughter (and lots of mosquitoes!)." ■



Team USA2, U26 Silver Medal Winners (from left): Jacob Freeman, Cornelius Duffie, Richard Jeng, Rory Xiao, Brent Xiao, npc Christian Jolly and Olivia Schireson



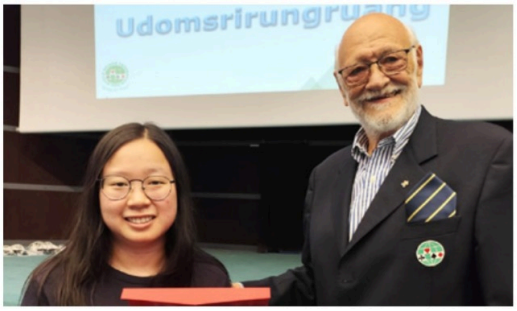
Team USA2, U21 Silver Medal Winners (from left): coach Xin Ge, Eric Xiao, Brandon Ge, Charlie Chen, npc Brian Platnick, Arthur Gong, Brian Zhang and Kayden Ge



Team USA1, U16 Silver Medal Winners (from left): Andrew Chen, Zinnia Meyer, Alex Shih, coach Steve Chen, Adam Hemmer, npc Alex Kolesnik, Kyo Chen and Jeff Xiao



Team USA1, U21 Bronze Medal Winners (back row, from left): Jack Boge, Ethan Derman, Daniel Balof, Samuel Pahk and npc Aaron Silverstein; (front row): Michael Haas and Avery Silverstein



Jessica Udomsrirungruang receives the Joan Gerard Sportsmanship Award for the U31 category.

Photos courtesy of the USBF